

The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter



Photograph: Getty Images

Donald Trump said he would soon “make a determination” regarding American [arms sales to Taiwan](#), but “made no commitment either way” when discussing the island’s defence with **Xi Jinping**. China earlier warned America that the issue could result in “conflict” if “mishandled”. America’s president also said he might lift sanctions on Chinese oil refiners that purchased Iranian oil. [Few deals emerged](#) from the two-day summit.

Abbas Araghchi, Iran’s foreign minister, said that America’s “contradictory messages” scuppered his country’s “trust” in negotiations. He said America needed to get “serious”. On Friday **Mr Trump** said a 20-year moratorium on **Iran’s** nuclear programme would be enough for him to end the war. He had previously maintained that he would accept nothing short of a surrender of Iran’s nuclear ambitions.

Israel and **Lebanon** agreed to extend their ceasefire for 45 days, America’s State Department said. It described talks between the two sides, held in Washington on Thursday and Friday, as “highly productive”—despite almost daily reports of Hizbullah and Israel trading fire across southern Lebanon. Political talks are scheduled to continue in June, with a security track starting at the end of May.

Britain's borrowing costs rose after **Andy Burnham**, Manchester's mayor, secured a path to challenge Sir Keir Starmer for leadership of the Labour Party. Mr Burnham will stand in a by-election after the incumbent resigned to make way for him (challengers to the prime minister must be MPS). [Political uncertainty](#) has helped push yields on 30-year gilts close to their highest level in almost 30 years.

An **Ebola** outbreak killed 65 people in the Democratic Republic of Congo. Nearly 250 cases have been reported in the Ituri province on the border with Uganda and South Sudan. Africa's health agency warned that it could spread rapidly because of intense population movement in the area. It is the 17th outbreak of the deadly virus in the country since 1976.

Russia and **Ukraine** swapped hundreds of prisoners of war as part of a deal brokered by Mr Trump earlier this month. Volodymyr Zelensky, Ukraine's president, said it was part of a bigger swap expected to involve 2,000 prisoners. Still, fighting has been intense: earlier this week Russia carried out the largest sustained attack on Ukraine since the war began, firing more than 1,500 drones.

Mr Trump said he will open a sculpture garden of American "heroes" in West Potomac Park in Washington, DC, which he described as a "totally BARREN field of prime waterfront real estate". (It sits near a public golf course where Mr Trump dumped debris from his White House renovation.) The president set aside \$40m for the development in his [Big Beautiful Bill](#) last year.

Word of the week: *Darshan*, seeing. [Read our obituary](#) of Raghu Rai, India's most famous photojournalist.



Photograph: Reuters

America snaps back sanctions on Russian oil

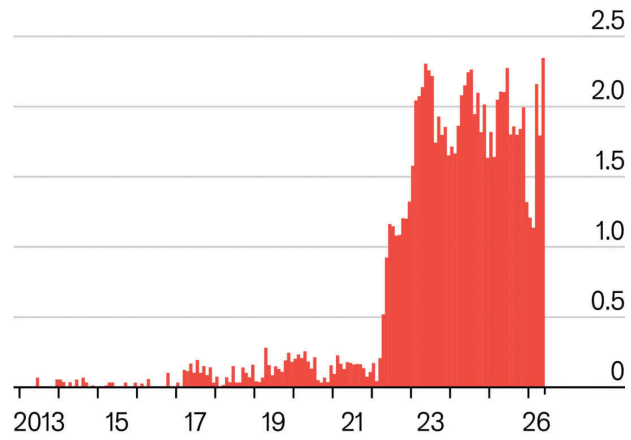
In March America allowed countries to buy Russian crude stranded at sea despite sanctions. The exemption was meant to ease petrol shortages caused by the closure of the Strait of Hormuz and push [oil prices](#) down globally. After two extensions, the waiver expires on Saturday.

India—which once sourced over 40% of its crude from the Gulf—has asked America to renew it. Before the Iran war America pressed India to curb purchases of Russian oil, and [India eventually complied](#). The waiver has changed things: Indian imports of Russian oil have soared since February, averaging a record 2.3m barrels per day so far in May.

Russian crude is similar in quality to common Gulf grades, making it easy for Indian refiners to process. There is little left to snap up: volumes of Russian oil at sea are at their lowest since August. But there are signs India has been stretching the waiver's terms. Ship-tracking data shows it has been buying Russian crude loaded after the waiver came into force.

Crude measure

India, crude-oil imports from Russia
m barrels per day



Source: Kpler



Photograph: Getty Images

The rise of Britain's far-right

Tommy Robinson, a far-right activist known for his anti-Muslim bigotry, holds a rally in London on Saturday. Several figures have been barred from entering Britain to speak at the event, including an American influencer who torched the Quran with a flamethrower in a viral video. Mainstream politicians shun Mr Robinson. Commentators dismiss him as “marginal”. He is too toxic even for Nigel Farage, the right-wing populist who leads Reform UK. Only 14% of Britons have a positive view of him according to one survey.

But the rally highlights Mr Robinson's growing influence. *YouGov*, a pollster, finds that 29% of British men like him, up from 9% in 2021. Elon Musk, the world's richest man and owner of the social-media platform x, amplifies his message (and reportedly pays his legal fees). His last rally in September drew around 150,000 people, the largest organised by the far right in British history. Like him or not, Mr Robinson is [shaping views on Britain](#).



Photograph: AP

A bitter primary in Louisiana

On Saturday voters in Louisiana head to the polls for the state's fiercest Senate primary in years. Bill Cassidy, a two-term Republican senator and doctor from Baton Rouge, is defending his seat against a Trump-endorsed congresswoman and the state's more hardline treasurer. After voting to impeach Donald Trump in 2021, Mr Cassidy has been trying to win back the president's favour, voting with him "100% of the time" and even backing Robert F. Kennedy junior for health secretary after criticising his anti-scientific views. But Mr Trump never forgot. Now he is calling on Louisianans to vote the senator out.

The attack is part of Mr Trump's [broader revenge campaign](#) against incumbents who have crossed him. In the midst of an unpopular war abroad and soaring prices at home, the president is more focused on purifying his party than going after Democrats. Some Republicans worry he is diverting money and attention away from races they need to win to keep control of Congress.

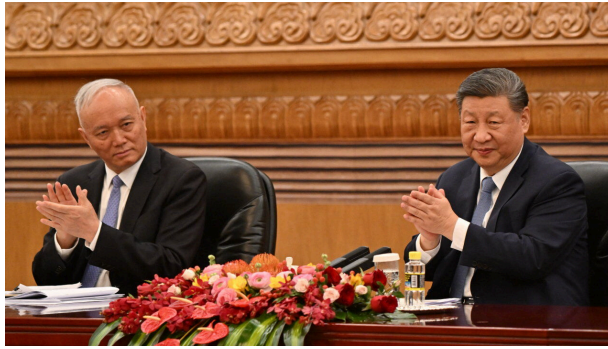


Photograph: EPA

The Vienna convention on undiplomatic relations

Eurovision's motto is "united by music". Over seven decades the song contest has certainly united viewers in joy as well as bemusement. For every "Waterloo" (1974) there has been an "Irlande Douze Points" (2008), screeched by Dustin the Turkey, a poultry puppet.

This year's final in Vienna on Saturday will not live up to the slogan. Iceland, Ireland, the Netherlands, Slovenia and Spain have not sent an entry in protest at Israel's participation. They object to [the war in Gaza](#), despite a ceasefire largely holding since October. Some of their national broadcasters will not even show the event. Things could be frostier, however. In November the inaugural Eurovision Song Contest Asia takes place in Bangkok. As recently as December soldiers from Thailand and Cambodia, two of the ten entrants, were killing each other in a [bitter border dispute](#). If that contest can create some amity between the two countries, it really will deserve *douze points*.



Photograph: Getty Images

Weekend profile: Cai Qi, China's second-most powerful man

In some photos of this week's meeting between Xi Jinping and Donald Trump, you can spot a tall, white-haired figure sitting to the right of the Chinese president. [Cai Qi](#) may be the second-most powerful person in China. As Mr Xi's right-hand man, in functional terms as well as seating plans, Mr Cai has insight into almost every area of policy and access to many of the Communist Party's secrets.

As chief of the party's powerful General Office, Mr Cai acts as Mr Xi's chief of staff, controlling his schedule and the people and information that reach him. But he also runs the body that implements leadership decisions and manages the party apparatus, and leads another that controls Mr Xi's personal security. Sometimes he even supervises Mr Xi's medical care.

The breadth and depth of Mr Cai's responsibilities is highly unusual. "Whenever people ask me, 'What happens if Xi were to drop dead tomorrow and there was no succession plan, who would get the top job?', Cai Qi seems like the obvious answer," says Jonathan Czin, a former China analyst at the CIA.

Born in the eastern province of Fujian in 1955, Mr Cai was sent to work in the countryside as a teenager, like Mr Xi, during the Cultural Revolution that raged across China between 1966 and

1976. When Mr Xi was posted to Fujian in 1985, Mr Cai was a junior official there. He later spent some 15 years working closely with Mr Xi in Fujian and neighbouring Zhejiang province.

His big break came in 2014 when Mr Xi brought him to Beijing to join the National Security Commission, a secretive body believed to include spies, generals and police chiefs. Within three years, Mr Cai was elevated to the Politburo, the party's top 25 leaders, despite not having previously been in the broader Central Committee. He then became mayor and later party chief of Beijing, where he appears to have impressed Mr Xi. He was also an energetic advocate of absolute loyalty to China's leader. That helps to explain his unusual appointment in 2023 to lead the General Office soon after joining the Politburo Standing Committee.

All of that suggests that the president values him as a hard-nosed enforcer and administrator. More importantly, he is not seen as a threat, as his swift promotion from relative obscurity means he does not have his own political powerbase. Instead, he derives his authority entirely through his relationship with Mr Xi.

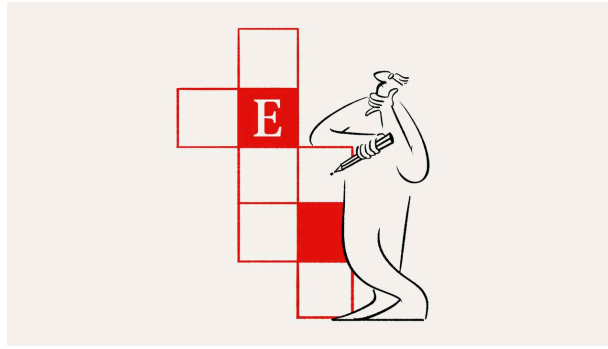


Illustration: The Economist

Mini crossword

We publish a new interactive edition of our crossword daily, allowing you to enter and check the answers and see explanations. Try it [here](#). Or, if you prefer, use the clues below.

There are two sets of clues, one for seasoned cruciverbalists and the other for less experienced solvers. Both give the same answers.

Cryptic clues

1 across - Flat, even if you spell it backwards (5)

2 across - Laura confused hearing (5)

3 across - Minor thought: what's my point? (5)

1 down - Tacit loan wiped out for milk production (9)

Straight clues

1 across - Flush; a stage in a computer game (5)

2 across - Relating to the ear or the sense of hearing (5)

3 across - Boreal, “up” on a map usually (5)

1 down - The process of producing and secreting milk (9)



Illustration: Sandra Navarro

The winners of this week's quiz

Thank you to everyone who took part in this week's quiz. The winners, chosen at random, were:

Yu Zhang, Mosman, Australia

Ayako Fukui, Singapore

Erik Mashkilleyson, Helsinki, Finland

They gave the correct answers of Leonardo da Vinci, Bill Clinton, Babe Ruth, Albert Einstein and Sir Paul McCartney. The theme is that they are all left-handed.

The questions were:

Monday: Which Renaissance artist had a sideline as a military engineer for Cesare Borgia?

Tuesday: Which American President was born in a town called Hope?

Wednesday: The departure of which baseball player in 1920 is supposed to have resulted in a long-lasting curse on the Boston Red Sox?

Thursday: Which famous physicist produced some of his most important work while employed at the Swiss patent office?

Friday: Which musician sang a duet with Stevie Wonder called “Ebony and Ivory”?

*You must write, and read, as if
your life depended on it.*

Andrienne Rich